

Session 18: The False Light

DM guide | Prepared from GitHub main and Session 17, September 29, 2026

Run this tonight

The intended arc is to manage the attack on Greenest, recover the hidden mill object, and leave north carrying it and the control plate to seek the dragon. This is prepared play, not a report of completed events. Start at the ending deployments; do not replay the council or camp. Allow a sensible plan to succeed. Resolve the attack through command decisions, short local confrontations and consequences, then give the mill discovery room to breathe.

Target: three hours. Opening 10 minutes; four-front operation 65; aftermath and regroup 15; mill recovery 45; northbound journey and dragon approach 35; close and record 10. If play runs long, cut repeated combat and travel checks. Preserve the reveal and a real departure choice. Excavation may finish next morning: elapsed fictional hours can pass in a brief montage after safety and care are arranged.

Preparation decisions introduced in this packet are marked PROPOSED. Scott's requested arc authorizes preparation; it does not establish future victory, deaths, item ownership, new world truth or an automatic level-up. Existing actual play controls wherever a prepared scene conflicts with it.

Opening dashboard

Front	Confirmed deployment	First meaningful question
Mill	Floyd GoldSeeker, Brother Kai, both work crews	Which seam is safe, who braces it, and who watches the entrance?
Ridge	Pat-Benatar, two guard teams	Capture, kill, drive off or isolate the two observers? What exact signal follows?
West path	Throk, third guard team	Observe, block, protect runners or patrol toward the mill?
North road	Severed Whisper alone	Tree concealment, visible bluff, or another opening posture?

Ask each player for one concrete opening order. Confirm the control plate's carrier; Severed Whisper last explicitly held it at camp. Confirm the two carts, runner route, rally point and retreat signal. Do not quietly transfer the plate to Throk because older Session 16 notes say he held it.

Resource check: five level-2 PCs; sheet values last refreshed September 1. A short rest was initiated in Session 17, but individual recovery is unverified. Healing Word on Doss was cast with uncertain attribution and amount. Two shields were acquired with recipients uncertain. Confirm current HP, slots, hit dice, features, ammunition, consumables and equipped shields with players. No automatic long rest or level-up. Resistance potion types and minor-healing-potion mechanics remain unconfirmed. Doss is in sanctuary care; Mara continued north. No 40 gp was paid.

Preserve the existing protected background: town guards outside the three reassigned teams still guard their posts; sanctuary care continues; the bridge was not burned. Council location labels remain unresolved. Do not settle those discrepancies through descriptive art.

Enemy order card: what actually releases Spade

Wheel has two straw-loaded wagons, six shields originally (two taken at camp), two drums, no ram, ladders or occupation supplies. They arrive visibly at dusk, make noise and await further orders before entering. Prepared head count: PROPOSED four hired raiders, two per wagon; not a new historical fact.

Lantern has two observers on the ridge. After drums begin, they watch defenders. One long shuttered flash only when defenders move north. Otherwise hold and send a runner. These are observers, not suicidal champions.

Spade has eight people with picks, pry bars, rope and timber braces. Foot-only east drainage route to mill work entrance, then shallow space beneath. Brace and breach masonry beside the sealed arch. Retrieve contents; keep mill and channels standing. Do not await the plate. Move only on one long shuttered flash; otherwise hold.

Enemies do not know secret friendly deployments unless they observe them or receive a report. Camp personnel heard that the party carried the plate; that does not locate it at dusk. A sent runner takes time. No telepathy, unseen reinforcements or automatic dragon retaliation.

Resolve four fronts without four separate full battles

Use three operation beats of roughly five to ten fictional minutes. At each beat, give every front a short scene and one consequential choice, then update only effects actually caused. When a local fight needs initiative, stop the operation clock for its few rounds; do not let ten fictional minutes pass while another player says one sentence. Across distant fronts use local initiative; characters cannot share spells, sight or turns across the town.

Write four states on paper: Ridge [enemy / contested / party]; Wheel [waiting / suspicious / withdrawing / advancing]; Spade [holding / scouting / moving / withdrawn]; Mill [unbraced / braced / clearance / access / recovery]. Add each runner's departure, destination and arrival. PROPOSED communication: a nearby post takes one beat; opposite fronts two beats. These are broad scene durations, not surveyed distances. Confirm against the established strategy map; never promise remote help in the same six-second round.

A credible task within a team's capacity succeeds without a roll. Roll only when opposition, risk or timing matters. Prepared command DCs: 10 straightforward under pressure, 12 disputed or watched, 14 difficult deception with contradictory evidence. Clear tools, terrain or preparation may grant advantage. State what failure costs before rolling. One failed command changes a position or costs time; it does not randomly kill a team.

PROPOSED guard-team abstraction for scenes without PCs: Fresh -> Pressed -> Withdrawn. Good cover and explicit limited orders hold a matching threat. A costly unsupported move makes the team Pressed; a second unsupported setback makes it Withdrawn with injuries needing care. Do not declare deaths from this track. If individual lives become central, resolve their actual situation. Both ridge teams cooperate against two observers; do not invent extra enemies to erase their numerical advantage. Volunteers brace, haul and dig; they do not become combat squads.

Beat 1: the drums and the shutter

Read A1 opening, then A2 drums. Ask Severed Whisper's posture before wagons arrive. He can watch from the tree, step onto the road, challenge the convoy, damage equipment, bluff about reinforcements or withdraw. Wheel wants visible noise, not instant occupation. Its wagon leader asks who stands for the town. A plausible threat can delay them; a lone adventurer does not automatically convince four people that an army exists.

At the ridge show two observers, shuttered lantern, hooded supply light, rock cover and escape path. Pat-Benatar has already brought enough support to isolate them. Let her distribute the two teams: one covers retreat while the other supports her approach, or both demand surrender. If concealed surprise is uncertain, compare the chosen approach to watchers who are currently looking toward town. If combat starts, use the existing S16 Hired Raider

block for the observers. They surrender when cornered or one falls, unless the party chooses lethal force. Honor that choice; do not narrate a kill before attacks resolve. Capturing the lamp intact is separate from incapacitating observers.

At the mill Floyd GoldSeeker can freely distinguish the old arch from the adjacent breach route. The lock is physically damaged; fitting the plate will not make the break disappear. Both crews can start quiet shoring. Brother Kai decides entrance watch, labor assistance or patient protection if someone is hurt. The old structure requires engineering, not a new four-statue puzzle.

At the west path give Throk a fair visible cue: a person on foot stops to look uphill toward the ridge, carrying no wagon load. PROPOSED this is the ordinary messenger allowed by the signal order. Throk can observe, question, stop, escort or let the messenger pass. The west path is not silently renamed the east drainage route. This front supports information and protects cross-town runners; it is not automatically Spade's route.

Beat 2: the party's signal changes the enemy's choices

Party action	Immediate consequence	Spade response
No flash; defenders stay in place	Written trigger absent	Holds; may send the ordered runner
Repeated/panic flashes	Not the authorized one-long-flash code	Holds, seeks clarification; does not automatically run into an ambush
One long flash after a convincing visible northward movement	Plausible valid trigger	Advances on foot toward mill; party can prepare interception
One long flash without observed movement	Contradictory evidence	Foreman sends a scout; eight do not charge blindly
Lamp broken or captured before signal	Observation link lost	Holds until information arrives; party gains time
Captured observer or convincing messenger supplies changed orders	Evaluate authority and what recipient can verify	Bargain, delay or redirection becomes possible

Pat-Benatar's false signal is the main bet. Ask what she wants enemies to believe. Repeated flashes can create doubt and buy excavation time; their success is disruption, not a magical panic code. If she wants to lure Spade in, she must meet or credibly explain the trigger. The party may choose darkness; preserve the late-session alternate proposal.

Wheel can notice a captured ridge, absent response or a provocative north-road challenge. Give it one observable reaction: drums hesitate, wagon leader looks uphill, or a runner departs. The convoy does not gain knowledge of the mill automatically. Let Severed Whisper decide whether to keep the feint occupied or pursue the messenger. A prepared escape down the townward road is available. Avoid focusing four simultaneous attackers on one wounded level-2 rogue for a mandatory combat.

Throk's team can secure a messenger and ask what was actually written. Useful plain answer: "We wait for one long light. If the town stays put, we wait." If a captured messenger knows the northern transfer marker, that is route evidence, not knowledge of the dragon's secrets. Preserve messenger identity as an unnamed role unless a player asks.

Beat 3: meet the actual attack, or protect the time you earned

If Spade holds, reward the signal plan. No obligatory mill combat. A brief attempted reconnaissance or negotiation is enough; the party has prevented the coordinated opening. If it advances, show water splashing and a covered tool knocking stone before contact. Eight pairs of boots is a count of the work party, not eight soldiers of equal threat.

PROPOSED Spade staging: two hired-raider escorts with six laborers. Laborers do not attack in formation; they drop tools, take cover, bargain or flee. A foreman can be one of the laborers, with no elite block. The escorts' goal is access and safe withdrawal. In tactical play place both escorts and the visible workers. Do not add a boss or hidden waves. Floyd GoldSeeker and Brother Kai can hold a braced choke, warn workers of collapse, negotiate with the foreman or call support. A sensible barrier changes the encounter before initiative.

If ridge and road clashes happen, use only brief local combats necessary for choices. Large forces retreat when their cover story or coordination fails. Capture is a real option. Wheel is not equipped to besiege Greenest. A battle can conclude with frightened hired people alive and the town secure.

If pressure overwhelms a front, runners and withdrawal are the consequence. Civilians can be injured and care can cost time, but no offscreen massacre is required. The intended successful arc remains available through regrouping, guarding the mill, bargaining or seizing the next opening. If players abandon all protection or lose the contents, preserve that result and revise the northbound objective; never retcon success to reach a prepared scene.

Quick local combat reference

Existing campaign S16 Hired Raider: AC 12, HP 9, speed 30 feet, club +3 to hit, 1d4+1 bludgeoning. Prepared two observers, two Spade escorts, four Wheel occupants reuse it when they actually fight. These are campaign blocks, not an assertion of an official monster stat block. All enemies have independent HP. No multiattack, spellcasting or ranged weapon invented. For a noncombatant use existing Commoner record; avoid attacking statistics unless play needs them. Use the table's chosen D&D rules for attacks, cover, concealment and nonlethal options.

Resolve allied guard help as position, containment and sensible pressure rather than adding a dozen NPC turns. If the team is physically in a fight and a player needs precise attacks, use its existing Roll20 guard record; do not use the Fresh/Pressed track as extra HP or an undisclosed combat buff.

Aftermath: the town is safe enough to work

Regroup only after runners actually communicate. Read A7 aftermath with the appropriate success or mixed-result paragraph. Nighthill wants confirmed facts: who is hurt, who is missing, which approach is secure, and whether the mill crew can continue. Escobert restores ordinary watches and keeps the two carts useful for casualties or hauling. He does not automatically award a title. No invented bounty or 40 gp courier payment.

Offer a brief personal question to each PC: what do you check before leaving your post? Pat-Benatar can inspect the lamp or prisoners; Severed Whisper can retain convoy papers; Throk can account for his team; Brother Kai can check workers; Floyd GoldSeeker can verify the supports. This records care and supplies instead of assuming a flawless victory.

The mill: earn access without losing the session

Both crews may need until next morning. Initial work before the attack creates real progress; a successful defense permits uninterrupted continuation. Keep a progress record: support plan; safe clearance; accessible opening; supported recovery. A correct practical description accomplishes its step. Use DC 12 only for rushed or uncertain execution, DC 14 if attempted under attack. Help and suitable tools matter. A setback costs an hour, bent equipment or a need for extra bracing, not removal of the only clue. Stop and secure the structure before retrying.

Floyd GoldSeeker spots load lines, old masonry and ordinary tool marks freely. Name the problem: remove the mortar/stone beside the sealed arch without letting the mill's newer load settle into it. Timber wedges and transverse bracing support that load. Crews work in shifts; Brother Kai can hold a guide rope, pass tools, keep dust clear or protect an entrant. No skill roll makes workers immune to danger.

The familiar seam still carries water upward. The arch remains shut; the side access is a separate human-sized aperture into a small maintenance recess. The crews are not repairing the ancient mechanism merely by removing bricks. After completion they stabilize the hole, mark it unsafe for casual visitors and leave the channels standing. Make a final custody check for the plate.

Optional CLICK, only if not overused recently: first describe a brace end sliding in damp stone, a slow shower of grit and a worker leaning beneath the load. Then the isolated CLICK prompts one immediate action per present PC in three seconds. Nearby PCs only; distant PCs cannot teleport. Appropriate actions secure position or protect the worker. Use normal checks when needed; no instant death. This is an avoidable engineering complication, not punishment for good work. Omit if the pacing does not need it.

PROPOSED reveal: the pressure witness

Default prepared object if Scott supplies no other design: a forearm-length, roughly ten-pound smoky crystal spindle seated in three aged bronze ribs, resting in a padded stone cradle. It is portable. A thin amber thread hangs motionless inside. Small repeated lines resemble the geometric family of the Observatory and the old channels. Name "pressure witness" is a DM working label; players may name it.

Its proposed function is to retain a limited record of the local vault's last stable pressure pattern. It is a removable measuring/reference component, not the entire apparatus, a trapped soul, a dragon egg or another control plate. Removing it after disengaging its three retaining clips does not switch off the whole town. It grants no combat power, healing, prophecy or map overlay. The plate remains a separate interface component from the damaged socket. Neither item alone fixes the broken masonry channel.

Give one major observation now: the contained amber line briefly makes a second offset line when brought near the plate, then steadies. This demonstrates relationship, not a full cosmic explanation. Floyd GoldSeeker can recognize deliberate suspension and safe release. Brother Kai may hear an ordinary slight mechanical hum; no compulsory vision. Pat-Benatar can recognize familiar geometry without a forced ancestry answer. Severed Whisper can find the exit and packing route. Throk can protect the group while the item is lifted. Give everyone a useful action; do not force a divine voice or rewrite Glittervein.

Removal procedure: inspect cradle; support spindle with two hands or a sling; withdraw three visible clips; lift and wrap. Competent execution succeeds. If rushed, a warning scrape precedes damage: stop, support, retry. Do not shatter the session objective on one low roll. If players choose to smash or leave it, honor the choice and preserve route evidence independently.

DM-only PROPOSED dragon motive: Lennithon wants the witness's old baseline and the plate's interface to compare local pressure changes with a disturbance farther north. He is gathering useful measurements for his own interests. Frulam wants possession and leverage; she is not his commanding superior or subordinate by default. He knows more than the party about this instrument, but is not an all-knowing teacher and does not explain the entire rift. This reveal neither identifies the old departure omen nor makes dragons one united faction.

Three independent ways to get a northbound lead

PROPOSED transfer destination: a split basalt shelf beyond the northern camp, reached by following the cart road to its final chalk fork, then a foot track marked with three pale stones. It is a rendezvous, not an exact confirmed lair. Travel suggestion: a morning's journey beyond the camp; treat map distances as approximate and disclose supplies before departure.

1. A surviving/captured messenger or convoy docket carries the short transfer instruction in the handout. This is a logistics destination; it does not identify L.
 2. Mara can be found at the next transfer stop, if the party chooses to seek her. She knows the appointment place, not the crystal's function. Doss's care gives her a credible reason to help; no invented promise forces her loyalty.
 3. Follow the northbound road and recent transfer tracks toward the three-stone fork. A failed tracking check costs time or exposes a nearby lookout; it does not delete the only road. The remembered northbound dragon flight supports the search but is not an exact bearing to a lair.
- Reveal the route through one earned source and keep the other two as backups. Do not conjure a map from the spindle. Players can make a copy, ask directions, choose a scout or delay to rest. Set the plate and spindle holders explicitly before leaving.

Leaving Greenest

Nighthill can arrange ordinary food, water, blankets and a practical carrying sling as civic support; any coin reward needs Scott's decision. Escobert asks what repair/watch the town must continue after departure. Crews stay in Greenest unless asked and willing. Guard teams return to town duties; they are not a permanent adventuring army. Confirm Doss's continuing care, prisoners, and secured mill aperture.

A long rest happens only if players choose it and the conditions/time satisfy the table's rules. A dawn excavation does not itself grant rest to anyone who worked or stood watch. Do not force a no-rest departure. If departure is next morning, use A11 dawn version; if they leave at night, use its night version. Their northbound objective is finding the dragon and deciding what to do with both objects, not an automatic surrender.

Journey and dragon approach

Run one travel scene with a choice: main cart road offers clear tracks but observers; the foot route offers concealment but awkward hauling and slower progress. Keep supplies and injured characters relevant. No unrelated random fight needed. An old wheel rut, rubbed packing cloth and the three pale stones provide physical route confidence. Do not make the party solve the Wheel/Spade/Lantern puzzle again.

At the split shelf show the scale of a waiting presence without rolling dragon initiative. A low voice asks, "Which of you decided to bring both?" Only use this after the party approaches with both objects visibly or credibly declared. If concealed, the speaker asks what they came to deliver. No automatic detection through bags.

PROPOSED encounter is Lennithon, an independent dragon. Reveal name if he chooses to introduce himself or they ask; do not retrospectively confirm the flyover or departure omen as the same creature. Species/color depiction remains concealed in the approach artwork. There is no fair level-2 battle against a fully engaged adult dragon; stage conversation at a boundary with an open retreat route. Do not use him to punish the party for carrying the intended bargaining objects.

He wants to inspect the witness and plate, prefers controlled exchange, and offers a limited true observation: the spindle preserves how the place behaved before a recent change. He asks where it was found and whether the damaged channel was repaired. He can refuse to answer a larger question, propose terms or reveal his own concern. He does not own the items merely because he wants them. If attacked, let the first observable response communicate scale and allow withdrawal; do not manufacture a required suicide fight.

End option 1: first voice at the shelf, ready for Session 19 negotiation. End option 2 if time: one exchange, name earned, clear proposed terms, then end before handover. Ending read-aloud A13 must reflect actual custody and decisions. No obligatory bargain, friendship or dragon defeat.

Branches that keep the intended arc playable

If the false light fails: town defenders retain most posts; Spade's arrival becomes the short main confrontation. If an observer escapes: warning reaches a specific recipient after time, not every enemy instantly. If Wheel withdraws: take the earned breathing room and inspect abandoned evidence only where actually left. If the enemy gets into the mill: compete over access, use worker safety or negotiate; retrieval can remain a contested scene. If opening takes until dawn: montage the safe work, account for watches and recovery, then reveal. If the party refuses the item: still give the earned route and let them choose a different mission. If the party cannot safely leave: end with the recoverable situation and revise, rather than pretending the requested arc occurred.

Closing record

Actual front outcomes; observer/worker/prisoner status; guard injuries; precise signal used; Wheel/Spade awareness; mill damage/repair; object's observed appearance/function only; custody of plate and recovered object; whether supports remain safe; care promises; HP/resources/rests/advancement actually declared; northbound route and companions; any dragon name or statement actually heard. Keep testimony distinct from accepted fact. Save after play only on Scott's explicit request.

Packet use

Read-aloud pack contains gated player narration. Mental movie is a roughly forty-minute possible DM rehearsal, not scripted player decisions. Player handouts are individual release gates. Roll20 manifest records page order and actual installation status. New art uses the actual repository face references. Keep this guide, the movie and hidden handouts GM-only.